

COMMON SOCIAL MEDIA SCAMS

Scam Type	How to Recognize	Tips for Avoidance
Phishing Attempts	Unsolicited messages asking for personal information or directing you to a login page.	Verify the sender's identity; never share personal information. Use two-factor authentication.
Fake Giveaways	Offers that seem too good to be true, asking for shares, likes, or personal details.	Research the legitimacy of the offer; look for official account verification.
Romance Scams	Fast-moving relationships, often with requests for financial help or personal information.	Be sceptical of online-only relationships; never send money or share financial details.
Impersonation Accounts	Accounts mimicking friends or celebrities, asking for money or information.	Check for verification badges; verify with the person directly through another communication channel.
Investment Scams	Promises of high returns on investments through messages or comments.	Conduct thorough research; avoid unsolicited investment advice.

become fodder for cyberbullies, leading to harassment both online and offline.

- **Professional Repercussions:** Employers often review social media profiles, and inappropriate content can adversely affect current employment or future job prospects.

Setting Personal Boundaries

Establishing what is safe to share and what should remain private is crucial. Consider these steps to define your personal sharing boundaries:

- **Reflect on Your Sharing Goals:** Understand why you are sharing information online. Is it to keep friends and family updated, to network professionally, or to share hobbies and interests? Align your sharing practices with these goals.
- **Identify Sensitive Information:** Recognize information that should always remain private, such as your social security number, financial details, home address, and anything related to personal security.
- **Think Before You Share:** Before posting, consider the potential impact of your share on your privacy and safety. Ask yourself if this is something you would be comfortable with strangers knowing.

Educating Friends and Family

Your privacy is not only affected by what you share but also by what others share about you. Engaging in open discussions with friends and family about the risks of oversharing is essential.

- **Set Clear Boundaries:** Communicate your comfort levels regarding what others post about you, including photos, location check-ins, or personal information.
- **Advocate for Mutual Respect:** Encourage a mutual understanding of respecting each other's digital boundaries. Offer guidance on how to share responsibly, emphasising the importance of consent before posting content involving others.

Leveraging Privacy Tools and Settings

Social media platforms offer various tools and settings to help manage your digital footprint:

- **Review Tagging Settings:** Platforms like Facebook and Instagram allow you to review and approve tags before they appear on your profile. Enable these settings to control what others can share about you.
- **Use Audience Selectors:** When posting, use audience selectors to control who can see your content. Consider creating custom lists for more sensitive shares.
- **Periodic Privacy Check-ups:** Regularly review your privacy settings and the content visible on your profile to ensure unwanted information is not publicly accessible.

Creating a Safe Sharing Environment

Fostering a safe sharing environment involves being mindful of the content you share and its potential impact on others:

- **Promote Positive Sharing:** Encourage sharing that contributes positively to the community, focusing on constructive and uplifting content.
- **Be a Role Model:** Set an example of responsible sharing, demonstrating mindfulness and respect for privacy in your online interactions.
- **Support Others:** If you notice friends or family oversharing or at risk, offer support and advice on how to manage their digital footprint more securely.

By understanding the risks associated with oversharing and implementing these strategic practices, users can navigate the complex landscape of social media with greater confidence and security. This proactive approach allows for the enjoyment of social connections and community building online while safeguarding personal privacy and well-being. 